

TAMBARAM

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PRINCE FREDERICK

**K**. Jayaprakash observes that he is accustomed to witnessing the Ooty effect in Thiruvanchery, a panchayat nuzzling its back with a languid, feline-like ease against the relatively bustling Tambaram City. By evoking the pleasant Ooty climate, he is unconsciously taking the edge off a problem. In reality though, he cannot mitigate this problem, let alone solve it *in toto*: not he, nor his neighbours at a gated community in G.K.M. Nagar in Thiruvanchery.

Jayaprakash is president of Serenity Paradise Plot Owners' Association, a 147-unit community located in the tail end of Thiruvanchery panchayat. These residents have been witness to the local civic body's management of solid waste at close quarters, too close for their comfort. In Jayaprakash's as well as his neighbours' eyes, burning from smoke exposure, this is rank mismanagement. They are hoping against hope that the panchayat would treat some other residential zone to this "garbage tourism", because this has been going on for far too long, precisely for two years, since the establishment of Serenity Para-

# Mr. Smokey moves in next door

In Thiruvanchery, residents of a horizontally-aligned community, Serenity Paradise, are dealing with the fallouts of a garbage dump established by the local civic body. For want of a better site, this space serves as a garbage transit point

dise two years ago. It is not 'tourism' any more, but mundane, sickening everyday reality.

"Garbage is being dumped not far from our compound wall,

where our park is located. And it is set to fire every evening. We have made many representations to Thiruvanchery panchayat to stop the garbage dumping, but still wait to see results. The issue is long-standing, even the promoter having given up after waging a losing battle trying to get the civic body to discontinue the dumping," says Jayaprakash. "The garbage dump is interfering with the natural development of this resi-

dential space; plot owners are baulking at building on their piece of land, seeing the smoke from the garbage pile, when it is set to fire. It has become an uncomfortable constant every evening; at Serenity Paradise, we keep our doors and windows locked fearing a blast of smoke. The garbage dumping happens in what is said to be temple land, and besides our community, the campus of GKM College of Engineering and Technology is located nearby."

The problem "descends" as well as it "ascends". Jayaprakash points to possible groundwater contamination, as "the water tastes different", and he suspects leachate to be behind it.

He elaborates: "Our Association goes to great lengths to protect groundwater; one of the measures is enjoining members to avoid the use of septic tanks with choke pits and letting the refuse water into the ground. All of us use bio-septic tanks. Despite our best efforts, the water is getting spoilt, probably because of the garbage dumping at this spot."

▼  
The garbage dump; and (below) fire in the dump is a regular occurrence.





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# Residents irked by NHAI's reply

B. SARAVANAN

The reply from the National Highways Authority of India, Chennai, regarding the construction of additional culverts to drain water from 'Nattu Kalvai', an excess rainwater outlet channel of Thiruneermalai Periya Eri, below Chennai Bypass Road in Thiruneermalai region has come as a rude shock to residents.

Since Chennai Floods of December 2015 that wreaked havoc in the region, residents have been asking for additional culverts to divert rainwater from the channel into Adyar river, through a tributary.

The reply states that about 60,000 Passenger Car Units are plying on the stretch. Any further construction of structures across the highway will re-



quire traffic to be diverted, which may lead to several traffic issues.

The 25-foot-wide culvert is higher than the water le-

vel. We residents had asked for three culverts with a three-foot width (10 feet long and 10 feet wide), given the vast width of the 'Nattu Kal-

vai', which drains rainwater into the culvert.

Moreover, Pachai Malai and Veeraraghavan Eri excess water flows into the Eri.

Water flowing from the culvert on Chennai Bypass Road in Thiruneermalai.

PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

During rains, around 1,000 to 1,800 cusecs of water flows through the channel to the tributary connecting the Adyar river. Due to encroachments, floodwater enters areas near Kalvai in the region, causing flooding.

Work to lay Chennai Bypass Road and construct the culvert began in 2005 and was completed in 2010. It is sad to note that the Detailed Project Report (DPR) was not prepared keeping the future in mind.

NHAI should have constructed additional culverts, taking into account the rainwater catchment areas feeding Thiruneermalai Periya Eri, the flow of rainwater to the waterbody, and the anti-

cipated increase in the residential population over the next two decades, when the DPR was prepared and submitted.

Residents have been requesting NHAI to conduct a detailed analysis and alleviate the woes they face every monsoon since 2015, but no action has been taken.

When infrastructure or development work takes place, traffic is sure to be affected and diverted. Traffic can be diverted via Thirumudivakkam Main Road / 200-Foot Road (connecting Vandalur and Minjur) or an exit can be created on Bypass Road near the culvert (100 meters before) and an entry after 100 meters to join the Bypass Road.

However, the reply states that the matter has been referred to the project's supervision consultant and is currently under examination.

**B. Saravanan** is treasurer of Federation of Thiruneermalai Residents' Welfare Associations

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LIFFY THOMAS

**K**ey Performance Indicators (KPIs) might have a corporate ring to it, but is universal, touching every human connection, including that of residents of a gated community with their Management Committee (MC). A gated community in Manapakkam has understood this existential truth, hence an “appraisal” of every member of the MC against their self-imposed goals at the beginning of their term. The committee as a whole is assessed against its promises.

Casagrand Irene Owners Welfare Association (CGIOWA) believes it has set a benchmarks through this system. The framework encourages every member to give their best, and those performing well to get re-elected to the committee.

Spread across 5.6 acres with 295 dwelling units across 15 blocks and 13 villas, this gated community in Alandur Zone (Ward 157) of Greater Chennai Corporation is only seven years old.

#### Solar Power Ninja

Association secretary Lebbaeus Denis's KPI was around going solar. With flats ranging from 550 sq. ft. to 3500 sq. ft., the social profile of residents is varied, making buy-in a challenge. After multiple meetings, rooftop solar installation took off in three phases.

“Our 300 KWp rooftop solar project today powers the entire community's common areas including lifts, air conditioners in the club house, water pumps, gym, STP, water treatment plant,



At Casagrand Irene in Manapakkam, every member of the managing committee elected by residents is assessed by key performance indicators established for them

## KPI culture comes home

garden water pumping, street lights, car parking and all common lightings and EV charging stations. TNEB says we are one of the largest in Tamil Nadu's residential segment,” says Denis, who also oversees legal and asset management areas of the community.

Of the ₹1.4 crore invested to implement solar rooftop, CGIOWA took ₹1.25 crore from its corpus and the rest from the revenue streams it generates.

“Our annual electricity bill from the common areas generates over 5.13 lakh unit that translates to ₹ 60 lakh. We have begun to see solar PVC as a significant return on the investment we made,” says the secretary.

Currently, only 25% of rooftop terrace has solar pa-

nels and the rest of the space is available for future expansion of the solar initiative.

Casagrand Irene has brought out a brochure detailing the process and features: how the Association selected M/s Tamilnadu Energy System as vendor; technical specifications of solar panels and inverter; the break-up of electricity charges. With a message from former MLA T.M. Anbarasan, the brochure was distributed to close to 100 communities in the constituency.

#### Mr. Keep It Clean

Early this year, a team from Urbaser Sumeet documented best practices in waste management being adopted by the community. The architect of this system is said to be Karthikeyan M., assisted by his wife, Alagu K. The couple had moved in from Adyar, where they were part of many door-to-door

drives by Residents of Kasturba Nagar (ROKA).

“In my KPI, I had promised to make the community zero waste,” says Karthikeyan, joint secretary overseeing housekeeping operations and waste management. He maintains a tracking mechanism that shows how they collect and monitor waste on a daily and monthly basis.

Over the last six months, for instance, “black plastic cover” used to line garbage bins for wet waste disposal has been reduced from 591 kg to zero kg, thereby preventing plastic waste from going to dumping grounds.

The society also has an organic waste converter and is planning to procure more. “Waste management initiatives at the community are only four years old and we are taking baby steps. We hope to follow the three Rs with the support of residents, housekeeping staff and Urbaser Sumeet,” says Karthikeyan who works with an MNC.

Lebbaeus Denis says CGIOWA functions like a mini-corporate, every process is documented and there is an induction programme before a new committee takes over.

#### The Water Evangelist

For president Senthil Jagadeesan, interest lies in water. He oversees water conservation initiatives including ensuring runoffs go into the 75 recharge pits in the society and grey water is used in garden and for landscape.

Magesh Giri, joint secretary, also shares the ‘department’ with Senthil, overseeing garden and water management.

Ashok Premesh, treasure, is in charge of revenue management including compliance. Karthikeyan A.S., vice-president, oversees the security and parking management. Likewise, Govarthan, an assistant director in the film industry, was brought into the committee seeing the diversity he would bring to the table. Every Pongal, the society turns into a mini-village under his supervision. Denis says funds is not a constraints for MC members to function effectively. “We go all out to give them what they want and they do perform,” says Denis, a serial entrepreneur. “We have different revenue streams to generate funds. For instance, last year we opened a studio flat with all star facilities. By paying ₹2,000 a day, a resident can use it to accommodate a guest,” he says.

Of the 17 SDG goals, Denis says, the community has ticked seven goals required for community living, and has set its sights on other goals. It is working on getting ISO and LEED certifications.

▼  
An assembly of managing committee members; and a view of the villas.

PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT







T. ARVIND

**R**esidents, commuters and activists have renewed their demand for the closure of a Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation (TASMAC) outlet near the Chromepet bus terminus, alleging that the stretch has become unsafe due to tipplers, encroachments and illegal traders.

The liquor outlet, located on GST Road service lane opposite Chromepet railway station and close to the bus terminus, has become a major bottleneck for pedestrians accessing buses and trains.

#### Safety concerns

Office-goers and students said the already narrow service lane had further shrunk due to encroachments, haphazard parking and the loading and unloading of liquor stock.

V. Santhanam, founder of People's Awareness Association and the Chromepet Rail Users Forum, said TASMAC outlet had earlier been sealed following complaints

## An intense call to close **TASMAC outlet** near Chromepet bus terminus

Women commuters and residents cite safety concerns;  
TVK MLA says representations will be made if the outlet is  
left out of the State's closure list

regarding an illegal bar nearby, but was later reopened.

"Tipplers occupy the stretch leading to the foot overbridge escalator, which has remained defunct for more than a year. There have also been physical fights in the area," he said.

Residents alleged that anti-social elements often loitered near the escalator and pedestrian pathway, making women commuters uncomfortable.

Reshma, a student of a private college in Kattankulathur, recalled

an unpleasant experience while rushing to catch a bus. "A drunk man spat on me while I was walking on the road," she said.

A nursing student from a nearby medical college said she avoided waiting alone on the service road. "I wait for my father to pick me up because the place feels unsafe," she said.

Vijayalakshmi, an office-goer who parks her vehicle at a nearby parking facility, said women commuters were the worst affected while returning home in the

evenings.

"The nuisance created by tipplers affects our business too," said Hanifa, an attender at one of the parking stands used by office-goers.

Activists said repeated representations had been submitted to various departments, including the district administration, seeking closure of the TASMAC outlet.

#### Escalator issue

Residents said encroachments by eateries had worsened pedestrian

movement on the narrow stretch. Dumping of food waste into open drains had also raised hygiene concerns.

Meanwhile, the Highways Department has begun work to install a new escalator on the western side of the foot overbridge. An official said rodents attracted by waste dumped near eateries often damaged escalator components.

"The authorities should take action against eateries violating rules. The TASMAC outlet should also be closed," the official said.

#### Closure demand

On May 12, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay announced the closure of 717 TASMAC outlets across the State, including shops located near places of worship, educational institutions and bus termini.

Activists pointed out that the Chromepet outlet was situated within a few hundred metres of the bus terminus and opposite the railway station. However, there was no clarity on whether the outlet had been included in the closure list.

When contacted, newly-elected Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) MLA, Kamatchi said surveys were under way to identify TASMAC outlets that violated the government's guidelines.

"Even if this outlet has been left out, representations seeking its closure will be taken up," the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam MLA said.

Residents and commuters urged authorities to remove encroachments, restore the escalators and close the TASMAC outlet in the interest of public safety.



▼ An aerial view of the TASMAC outlet and the narrow service lane near the Chromepet bus terminus; and (top) pedestrians navigate through encroachments near the TASMAC outlet on GST Road service lane opposite Chromepet railway station; vendors occupying a portion of the Chromepet railway foot overbridge.  
PHOTOS: T. ARVIND



# Sting operations with a difference

On World Bee Day, meet three residents of Chennai who have established a bond with bees in very different ways: from managing structured frame hives in urban backyards to nurturing colonies on city campuses, and allowing a wild hive to thrive undisturbed in a neem tree at home

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

## Removing bugs, raising bees

For Rajendran Tamilarasam, an IT professional based near Tambaram, beekeeping exists alongside software work, family life and ecological advocacy: a parallel world sustained less by commerce than by fascination. Originally from Mullukurichi village near the foothills of Kolli Hills in Namakkal district, he traces his interest in bees back to childhood memories of accompanying his maternal uncle during honey collection from wild colonies formed on coconut trees. "I would stand below creating smoke while he climbed up to harvest honey," he recalls. Smoke, he explains, temporarily disrupts the bees' scent-based communication system, reducing their ability to signal danger to one another. "This way, both we and the bees stay safe."

Nearly a decade ago, that childhood curiosity gradually evolved into T R Bees and Apiary, a small-scale urban bee farm in Chennai. Operating from the Madambakkam, Rajendran now manages backyard bee colonies while balancing his full-time IT career. Supported closely by his wife, he sells bee colonies to households interested in setting up



hives at home and conducts awareness programmes on pollination, bee behaviour and colony maintenance. Initially, he says, the initiative began as an educational effort aimed at helping people understand how bees contribute to pollination and biodiversity. Over time, increasing public awareness transformed the nature of his work. "Earlier, people immediately called pest control services.

Now many contact us to rescue colonies instead of destroying them," he says. Much of his work in Chennai involves relocating giant hives from apartment buildings and commercial

spaces to safer environments near forested areas. He also trains residents in maintaining backyard hives, inspecting colony health and handling bees safely. Contrary to assumptions about urban spaces being hostile to pollinators, he believes Chennai's mixed vegetation offers bees a surprisingly stable food network throughout the year. "One house may have moringa trees, another ornamental flowers, another coconut or banana plants," he says. "So throughout the year, bees get different nectar sources."

He can be contacted at 99625 91218.

## 'Admissions' on campuses

K. Vasanthakumar moved to Chennai in 2001 after erratic rainfall disrupted farming at his village in Rajapalayam. In the city's dense neighbourhoods, he was quick to notice what others ignored: flowering drumstick trees spilling over compound walls and scattered open plots still capable of sustaining bees. "In those days, areas like Anna Nagar and Arumbakkam had plenty of flowering plants. I felt bees could survive even in a city like Chennai," he says. That instinct deepened in 2006, when he helped a resident in Medavakkam install a bee box that yielded nearly three kilograms of honey within a month. "I was very surprised that we got to eat honey, especially in a city," he recalls. The following year, additional colonies migrated naturally to the area and the yield rose further, convincing him to transport the rest of his bee boxes permanently from his native village to Chennai.

Today, from Kolathur, he runs Amudha Bee Farm, a modest but sustained urban beekeeping initia-

tive rooted in practices inherited from his grandfather. He installs bee colonies in residential compounds, the Guindy horticulture, the Khadi and Village Industries Commission (KVIC) campus in Madhavaram and shaded open spaces with sufficient flowering vegetation. In villages, he explains, colonies form easily near coconut groves and wells. In Chennai, however, survival depends on carefully identifying quieter pockets insulated from traffic, disturbance and excessive heat.

The process begins with a wooden bee box fitted with frames containing worker bees, broods and a queen bee. As the queen lays eggs and the colony expands, overcrowding is prevented by shifting the queen and a few bees into another box, allowing a fresh colony to emerge naturally. Honey extraction, he says, is done carefully using gloves, veils and controlled smoke so that neither the bees nor the honey are harmed. Alongside honey production, Vasanthakumar also prepares small batches of beeswax-based lip balms, face creams and pain balms. "Honey keeps the skin soft and protected, while beeswax locks in moisture naturally," he says, describing them as gentler alternatives to chemical-heavy skin care products.

He supplies bee boxes and live bee colonies on order, along with honey and beeswax-based products. His range of cosmetics includes a 25-gram face cream priced at ₹100 per box and lip balms priced at ₹100 per piece. Yet, despite growing awareness around pollinators, fear continues to influence public attitudes towards bees. "Many people are scared because bees sting. But bees are soft in nature unless they feel threatened," he says. He can be contacted at 99418 68926.



## Summer home stay

Every summer, residents of Nallappa Street in Chromepet begin looking towards a neem tree inside M. Sreedhar's compound that has, over the years, become an unlikely refuge for migrating wild bees. For nearly seven years, colonies have returned to the same branches, building large suspended hives that remain there for



months before dispersing once again.

Unlike conventional beekeepers who manage colonies through wooden frames and controlled extraction, Sreedhar practises a quieter form of stewardship. He does not harvest honey or interfere with the hive. Instead, he simply allows the bees to arrive, inhabit the tree and eventually leave on their own terms.

"For the past six years, every year the bees come, build a nest and stay there for around three to six months depending on the cli-

mate," he says. "The current nest would be the eighth one built here."

This year, however, the bees have been delayed. Sreedhar attributes the absence partly to excessive humidity and increased pesticide spraying in nearby areas. Yet he remains hopeful they will return once conditions improve.

According to him, the bees' repeated migration is closely tied to the environment his family has cultivated around the house. Over the years, they have planted near-

ly 30 native trees within the compound, creating a shaded corridor that supports birds, insects and pollinators alike.

"These are not ordinary bees," he says. "They require a healthy ecosystem. There should not be too much noise, disturbance or harsh sunlight." Far from provoking fear, the colonies have gradually become accepted within the neighbourhood. During one season, residents even switched off exterior lights at night after noticing bees becoming disoriented and dying from the heat.



T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

**A**t Meenambakkam bus stop on GST Road, towards Saint Thomas Mount, commuters can be seen waiting under the sky to board the buses. This is not because the haltover does not have a roof. In fact, there is a spacious shelter with good seating facility. However, the area along the elevated haltover is used as a parking lot.

Commuters have requested Metropolitan Transport Corporation to ensure the stopping point is free of vehicles.

A. Akilan, a commuter, says, “Due to parking of vehicles, buses halt on the road before and after the stopover area. Commuters hurry from the sheltered area to board the buses. When rushing to board buses, motorcyclists get moving, blocking the way for commuters.”

D. Thendral Dinakaran, a commuter, says, “We have to hurry from our waiting area and signal the driver to halt. At times, drivers do not halt, unless there are enough number of commuters alighting at the haltover.”

This affects traffic on the stretch. MTC should create a bus bay and deploy bay keepers.”

Pedestrians are also affected and have to walk on the carriageway amid traffic.

An email from MTC stated that the complaint has been taken note of and that necessary action will be taken to address it.

## Meenambakkam bus stop serves other vehicles



▼ A row of vehicles parked along Meenambakkam haltover on GST Road. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

## A monthly craft workshop series

**C**lub Artizen is launching OMRt – a monthly series of hands-on craft workshops designed to help residents along OMR slow down, create mindfully, and reconnect with the joy of making things by hand.

Open to everyone aged 11 and above – regardless of prior experience – the series brings together traditional artisans, contemporary craft practices, and community participation in relaxed, accessible weekend sessions, said a release. Each edition of OMRt will introduce participants to a different craft form while encouraging intentional, screen-free engagement and meaningful social interaction.

The inaugural workshop, Newspaper Craft: Coiling and Weaving, will be conducted by experienced artisans from Wellpaper, a Pondicherry-based enterprise known for its innovative newspaper craft products. The session will take place on 23 May, from 10:30 a.m. to 1:30 p.m., at Wang’s Kitchen, Navalur.

Participants will learn how discarded newspapers can be transformed into functional and decorative objects using coiling and weaving techniques, while also gaining insight into the value of handmade, sustainable craft practices.

“OMRt is about creating small pockets of pause in everyday life,”

said Meera Rajagopalan, co-founder of Club Artizen. “Working with our hands changes the pace of thought. It allows people to step away from constant consumption and experience the satisfaction of making something tangible with our hands.”

For registrations and details, call 97909 52129.

Club Artizen creates products, experiences, and collaborations that connect contemporary audiences with craft, culture, and mindful creativity. Through workshops, storytelling, and designed initiatives, the platform works to make traditional arts more accessible and relevant to modern life. Visit [www.clubartizen.com](http://www.clubartizen.com)

## MSME training programmes

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME, is conducting a workshop on baking from May 19 to 22. According to a press release, the pro-

gramme will focus on making cookies, pizzas, breads, and cakes from millets, wheat, and heirloom rice varieties.

### Preparation of DPR

The institute is also conducting another workshop on “Detailed Project Report Preparation” from May 21 to

22. The session will focus on basics of entrepreneurship, market survey, industrial policy of the State, and MSME classification and registration. Both the programmes will be held at the institute’s premises on SIDCO Industrial Estate, EDII Institute Road, Guindy. Phone: 8668102600



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# Graduation day of MCC School of Continuing Education



At the graduation day event. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The 26th graduation day of MCC School of Continuing Education, Madras Christian College, East Tambaram, was recently held at the Center for Media Studies.

A total of 145 students were awarded diplomas and PG diplomas by P. Wilson, principal and secretary of Madras Christian College, who presided at the event.

He appreciated that the faculty members have integrated industry-rele-

vant training and hands-on modules into the curriculum, ensuring that students are not just degree-holders but 'industry-ready' professionals.

Udaya Sankar, director of Nasscom Talent Council and co-founder of Maatram Foundation, was the guest of honour. He focused on the necessity of continuous upskilling to navigate a rapidly evolving job market and the importance of aligning personal talents with global industrial demands.

## Yoga session in Chromepet

Isha Yoga is conducting a seven-day yoga session in Tamil, aimed at self-exploration and transformation, starting from May 20.

The sessions will be conducted at Ayyasamy School, Nehru Nagar, Chromepet, from 6 to 8.30 a.m. and 6 to 8.30 p.m.

For details, call 9884986855.

## Student innovators included in awards

CavinKare, in association with the Madras Management Association (MMA), is inviting nominations for the 15<sup>th</sup> CavinKare-MMA Chinnikrishnan Innovation and Great Ideas Awards 2026.

This year's edition sees the reintroduction of the 'Great Ideas' category, revived with an expanded scope to include student innovators. The category will recognise 10 outstanding ideas, a significant scale-up from earlier editions where a single winner was awarded, said a release. Interested institutions and individuals can apply for the awards by submitting their entries on or before June 22, 2026 at [www.ckinnovationawards.in](http://www.ckinnovationawards.in). Or call 9444700068 to register.

The awards feature two categories: Innovation Category: Open to startups and MSMEs with proven, market-ready products or services that demonstrate uniqueness, scalability, sustainability, and tangible benefits to people.

Three winners in this category will receive a cash prize of ₹1,00,000, a citation and a trophy each. The 'Great Ideas Category' is open to individuals and institutions.

# Robotics enthusiasts showcase models

Vidhya Sagar Global School in Vedhanarayanapuram recently hosted a 'Robotics Cyber' exhibition.

Puneet Mehta, associate chief engineer, Mahindra and Mahindra, was the chief guest. The Information and Communication Technology Department, in collaboration with Cyber Bots (imparting robotics education), exhibited innovative models and games, including 'Nautica Quest' and 'Battle Bots.'

The enthusiastic students assembled various "minibites" and explained their uses to humans.

V. C. Govindarajan, principal, and parents interacted with the students at the exhibition. The principal presented a report on robotics at the valedictory function.

The winners were felicitated with certificates and medals by Puneet Mehta.



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